WHEN ALL THE CONTENT IS SYNTHETIC: THE TRUST PORTFOLIO



JOE PULIZZI

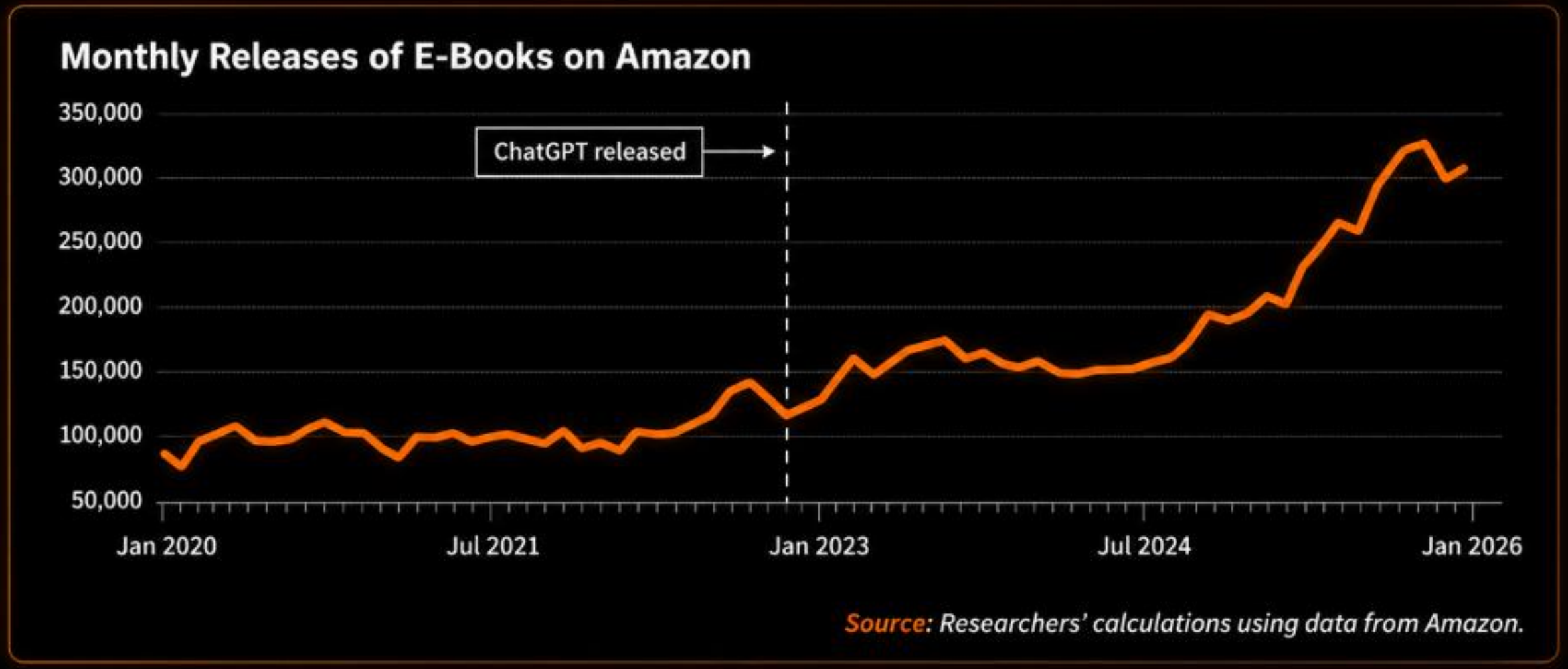
Founder

The Tilt



HOW LONG DOES IT TAKE TO WRITE AND PUBLISH A BOOK?

AI NOW DRIVES 50%+ OF NEW BOOKS



Source: Researchers' calculations using data from Amazon.

75%

OF NEW WEB PAGES CONTAIN AI-GENERATED CONTENT



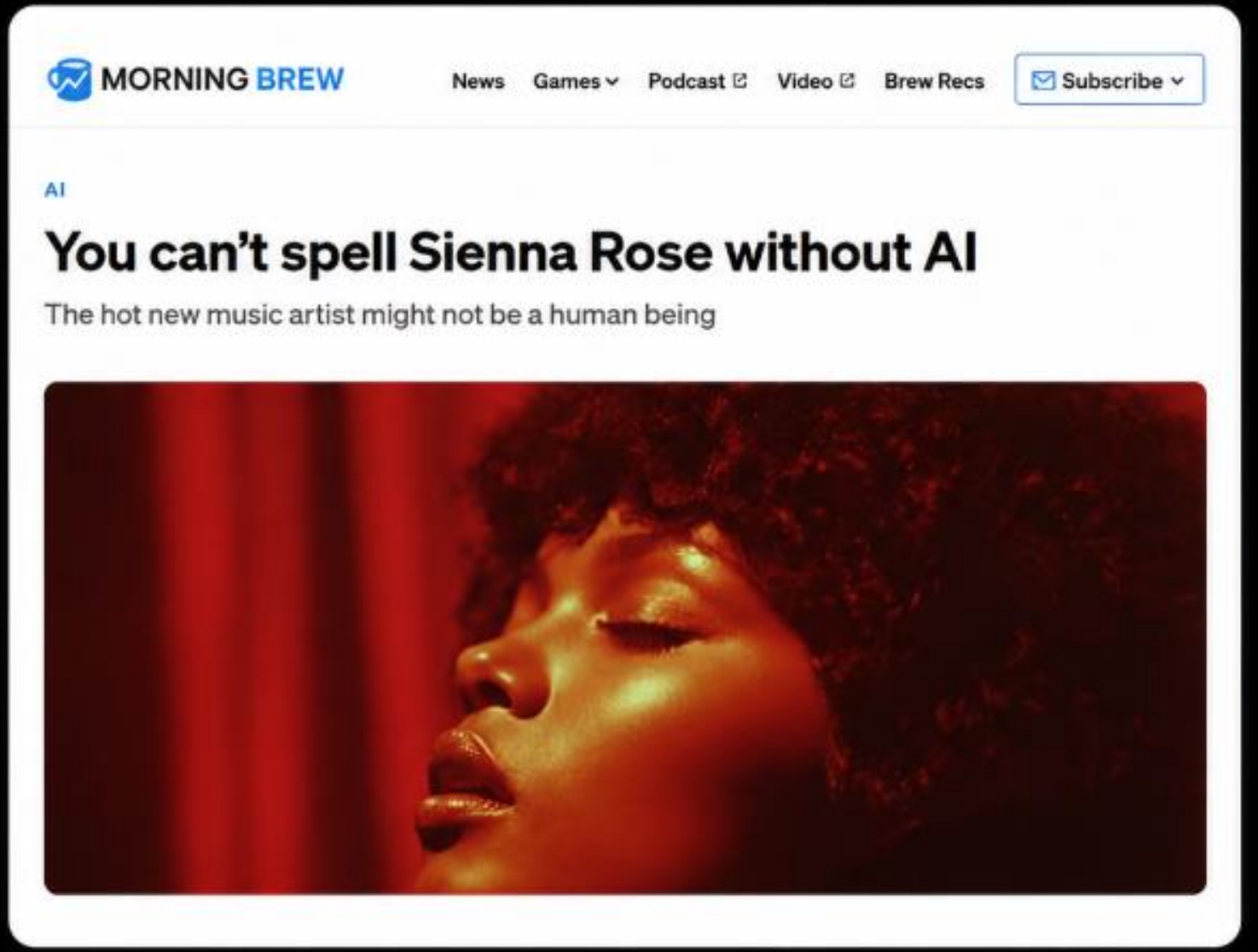
Source: Ahrefs

50%+ TIKTOKS ALL OR PARTIAL ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE



Source: *The Next Web*

AI ARTISTS HIT THE BILLBOARD TOP 100



Source: *Morning Brew*

WHY DOES THIS MATTER?

TRUSTED HUMAN VOICES ARE BECOMING MORE VALUABLE



In a world flooded with AI-generated content, trusted human voices **stand out.**


WEEKEND UPDATE
68%
of consumers frequently wonder whether what they see is real.
VS.
62% VS. 12%
comfortable with entirely human-produced news versus entirely AI-produced news.
8x
more likely to rank #1 on Google
Human-written content
per SEMrush
Image: Entertainment Weekly I Data: Gartner/SEMrush
WEEKEND UPDATE

THE HUMAN CHOICE PARADOX

AI WAS RATED HIGHER. PEOPLE STILL CHOSE HUMANS.



57%-62%

CHOSE HUMAN EMPATHY

Across 4 studies



AI RATED HIGHER

More empathetic
Higher quality



AI ALSO SCORED HIGHER

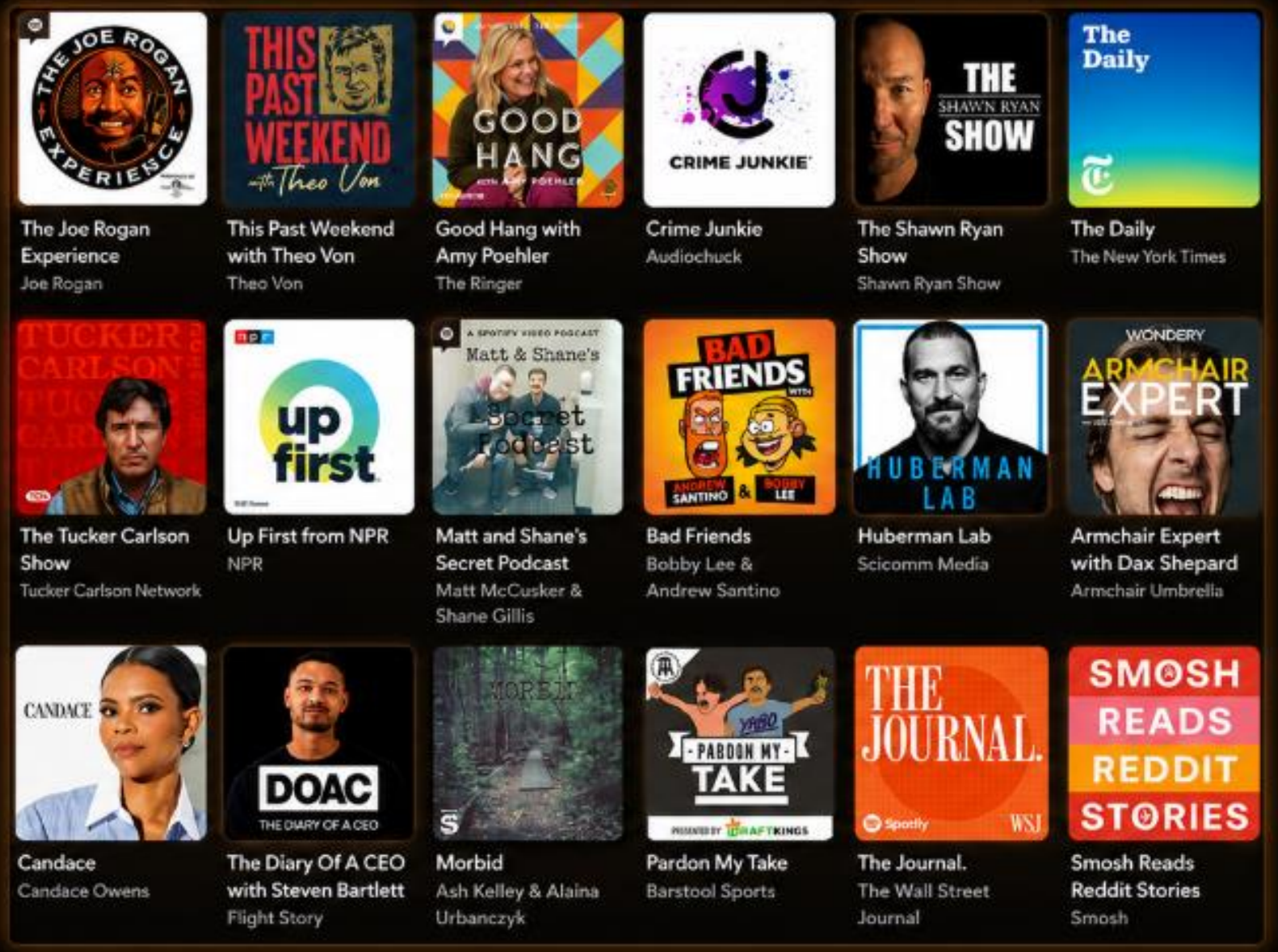
Made people feel more heard
and more understood

QUALITY ISN'T THE ONLY DECISION. WHO IT COMES FROM MATTERS.

Source: Wenger, Cameron & Inzlicht, *Communications Psychology*, 2026

THE HUMAN WINS ON SPOTIFY

Top podcasts on Spotify
are built around **real people**,
real stories and real conversations.



NY TIMES BETS ON PEOPLE

The New York Times is doubling down on what builds trust: real people with real perspectives.

DAILY

Opinion Today

Get expert analysis of the news and a guide to the big ideas shaping the world.

See the latest



TWICE A WEEK

Jessica Grose

A journalist and novelist offers her perspective on the American family, culture, politics and the way we live now.

See the latest



WEEKLY

David Wallace-Wells

The best-selling science writer and essayist explores climate change, technology, the future of the planet and how we live on it.

See the latest



WEEKLY

John McWhorter

A Columbia University linguist explores how race and language shape our politics and culture.

See the latest



WEEKLY

Frank Bruni

Reflections on the mess (and magic) of politics and life.

See the latest



WEEKLY

Jamelle Bouie

Historical context for present-day events.

See the latest



WEEKLY

Ross Douthat

The columnist reflects on culture and politics, but mostly culture.

See the latest



WEEKLY

David French

Reflections on law and culture, war and peace, and the deeper trends that define and divide America.

See the latest

HUMANS ARE PUCK'S MODEL

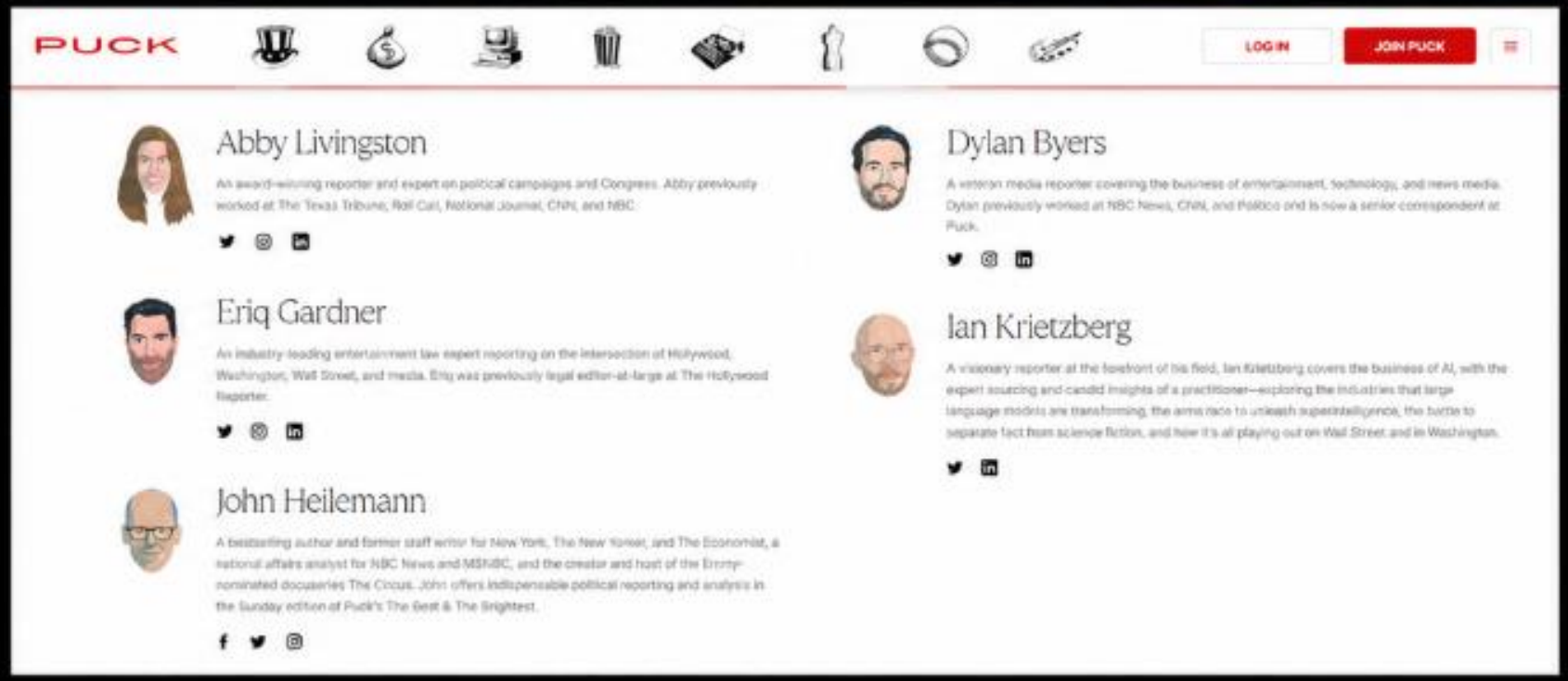
Puck doesn't just publish content. It builds franchises around trusted writers.



Inside Puck's Bet on Writer Ownership

Puck has built a different kind of media business by giving writers a financial stake in the audience they create. From subscriber-linked bonuses and equity to high-profile franchises and diversified revenue streams, its model shows how aligning writer incentives with growth can reshape both a newsroom and the business behind it.

By **Growth Curve**
August 27, 2026



Abby Livingston

An award-winning reporter and expert on political campaigns and Congress. Abby previously worked at The Texas Tribune, Roll Call, National Journal, CNN, and NBC.

Dylan Byers

A veteran media reporter covering the business of entertainment, technology, and news media. Dylan previously worked at NBC News, CNN, and Politico and is now a senior correspondent at Puck.

Eriq Gardner

An industry-leading entertainment law expert reporting on the intersection of Hollywood, Washington, Wall Street, and media. Eriq was previously legal editor-at-large at The Hollywood Reporter.

Ian Krietzberg

A visionary reporter at the forefront of his field, Ian Krietzberg covers the business of AI, with the expert sourcing and candid insights of a practitioner—exploring the industries that large language models are transforming, the arms race to unleash superintelligence, the battle to separate fact from science fiction, and how it's all playing out on Wall Street and in Washington.

John Heilemann

A bestselling author and former staff writer for New York, The New Yorker, and The Economist, a national affairs analyst for NBC News and MSNBC, and the creator and host of the Emmy-nominated docuseries The Circus. John offers indispensable political reporting and analysis in the Sunday edition of Puck's The Best & The Brightest.


MONEY

THE TRUST PORTFOLIO

DIVERSIFIED PORTFOLIOS WIN

RISKY

ONE STOCK INVESTING



- Single-company exposure
- Higher volatility
- Returns depend on one business

SMART

DIVERSIFIED PORTFOLIO



- Exposure across multiple sectors
- Reduced single-stock risk
- More stable long-term performance

BOTTOM LINE | One stock is a gamble. A diversified portfolio is a strategy.

THE TRUST PORTFOLIO

THIS IS HOW MOST OF US CREATE CONTENT

RISKY



ONE OR FEW VOICES
MOSTLY FROM THE BRAND

- Content muscle is concentrated in one place
- Credibility lives in one institutional brand voice
- Distribution depends on one primary channel or message stream
- Storytelling is centralized instead of spread across many perspectives

BOTTOM LINE | All the content muscle, credibility, distribution and storytelling are concentrated in one institutional voice.

SNL COULD NEVER WORK THIS WAY

SNL
A PORTFOLIO APPROACH



WEEKEND UPDATE

News. Satire.
A trusted voice for what's happening right now.



OPENING MONOLOGUE

Sets the tone.
Connects with the moment.
One voice, many perspectives.



CHURCH LADY

A character we know and love.
Timeless humor.
Instantly recognizable.



BLUES BROTHERS

Musical. Iconic.
Crosses generations.
Culture-defining moments.



WAYNE'S WORLD

Pop culture.
Generational connection.
Fun, irreverent, and unforgettable.



CONEHEADS

Weird works.
Unique ideas create lasting impact.



DIFFERENT VOICES. DIFFERENT ANGLES. ONE POWERFUL BRAND.
A PORTFOLIO BUILDS REACH, RESILIENCE, AND RELEVANCE.

IN A FLOOD OF SYNTHETIC CONTENT AND SAMENESS, BRANDS NEED A PORTFOLIO STRATEGY AS WELL.



DIVERSE VOICES. MULTIPLE FORMATS. DEEPER CONNECTIONS. GREATER IMPACT.

WE ARE SEEING THIS

1. IT JUST HAPPENS



Unplanned.
Inconsistent.
Easy to ignore.

2. YOU ENABLE IT



You invite others in.
You share the stage.
You create opportunity.

3. YOU BUILD IT ON PURPOSE



Intentional.
Strategic.
Built to last.

IT JUST HAPPENS

Staples

STAPLES

Chick-fil-A

CHICK-FIL-A

SOMETIMES TRUSTED BRAND VOICES EMERGE ORGANICALLY.

IT JUST HAPPENS

How Exciting Can Office Supplies Really Be? Ask the Staples Baddie.

Kaeden Rowland's videos that find whimsy in ballpoint pens and toner are traveling widely.



STAPLES

A Chick-fil-A Employee Was Told to Stop Posting Her Viral Menu Hacks — So She Got a Shake Shack Deal

Miriam Webb, known as "MiritheSiren" on TikTok, was working two jobs and 12-hour days before her Chick-fil-A videos blew up online

By Sabrina Weiss | Published on May 10, 2024 04:51PM EDT



CHICK-FIL-A

Sometimes trusted brand voices emerge organically.

YOU ENABLE IT

YOU OPEN THE DOOR. YOU GIVE PEOPLE A PLATFORM.
THEIR VOICES BECOME YOUR AMPLIFIERS.

GAP INC.



Beginning July 22, employees can engage with Old Navy, Gap, Banana Republic and Athleta as brand advocates and content creators.

YOU CREATE THE FRAMEWORK.
THEY CREATE THE CONTENT.

TEAM MEMBERS. REAL VOICES. REAL IMPACT.



YOU ENABLE THE PEOPLE.
THEY AMPLIFY THE BRAND.

I'M NOT RECOMMENDING YOU DO THAT.



IT COMES WITH RISKS.

You don't control the message. You share the stage.



YOU LOSE SOME CONTROL.

Their voice. Their style. Their decisions.



IT HAS TO ALIGN.

Values. Standards. Purpose. Audience.



IT MUST BE STRATEGIC.

Clear goals. Right people. Measured impact.



EMPLOYEE AND CREATOR PROGRAMS ARE NOT A HACK.
THEY ARE A STRATEGIC CHOICE—AND THEY REQUIRE LEADERSHIP.

THE TRUST PORTFOLIO

DON'T WAIT FOR IT.

DON'T JUST ENCOURAGE IT.

DESIGN IT.

DIFFERENT VOICES. DIFFERENT ANGLES. ONE POWERFUL BRAND.
A PORTFOLIO BUILDS REACH, RESILIENCE, AND RELEVANCE.

THE TRUST PORTFOLIO



ONE ORGANIZATION. MULTIPLE TRUSTED VOICES. MANY WAYS TO REACH THE AUDIENCE.

HUMAN-LED CONTENT FRANCHISES

PODCAST



NEWSLETTER



YOUTUBE SERIES



HUMAN-LED CONTENT FRANCHISES



WAYNE'S WORLD

CHARACTERS PEOPLE LOVE.
A POV THAT'S DISTINCT.
OVER AND OVER.

SNL
SATURDAY NIGHT LIVE

THE BLUES BROTHERS

A CORE IDEA.
A MEMORABLE STYLE.
CULTURAL IMPACT.





WEEKEND UPDATE

A RECURRING FORMAT.
TIMELY, TRUSTED,
AND ESSENTIAL.

THE FRANCHISE IS THE BRAND.
THE PEOPLE ARE THE REASON AUDIENCES COME BACK.

THREE-VOICE STARTER PACK



THE EXPERT

HELP ME UNDERSTAND.

Practitioner, researcher, subject-matter expert.

PODCAST | NEWSLETTER | YOUTUBE



THE STORYTELLER

TELL ME WHAT IT'S REALLY LIKE.

Frontline employee, customer success leader, product marketer.

TIKTOK | LINKEDIN | INSTAGRAM



THE ADVOCATE

REMIND ME WHY THIS MATTERS.

Executive, founder, board member, evangelist.

EVENTS | SPEAKING | PARTNERSHIPS

THREE DISTINCT VOICES. ONE STRONGER BRAND.
MORE REACH. MORE IMPACT. MORE LOYALTY.

VOICE #1:

THE EXPERT

Goal: **HELP ME UNDERSTAND.**

You explain the complex.
You break it down.
You earn trust through knowledge and clarity.



PRACTITIONER
You've done the work.

RESEARCHER
You dig deeper.

SUBJECT-MATTER EXPERT
You know your stuff.

PODCAST | **NEWSLETTER** | **YOUTUBE** | **WORKSHOPS & WEBINARS**

YOUR KNOWLEDGE IS YOUR ASSET.
YOUR CLARITY IS YOUR SUPERPOWER.

VOICE #2:

THE STORYTELLER

Goal: **TELL ME WHAT IT'S REALLY LIKE.**



You bring it to life.
You make it relatable.
You build empathy
through real stories.

FRONTLINE EMPLOYEE
You live it every day.

ENGINEER
You build what makes it work.

OPERATIONS MANAGER
You see how it really happens.

CUSTOMER SUCCESS LEADER
You know the customer journey up close.

PODCAST | NEWSLETTER | YOUTUBE | TIKTOK | LINKEDIN | INSTAGRAM

REAL PEOPLE. REAL STORIES. REAL IMPACT.
STORYTELLING CREATES UNDERSTANDING. UNDERSTANDING BUILDS TRUST.

VOICE #3:

THE ADVOCATE

Goal: REMIND ME WHY THIS MATTERS.



You connect the dots.
You inspire belief.
You mobilize people
to make a difference.

EXECUTIVE
You lead with vision and values.

BOARD MEMBER
You govern.
You guide.
You ensure impact.

INVESTOR
You back the mission and long-term growth.

STAKEHOLDER
You champion trust across the business.

PODCAST | NEWSLETTER | YOUTUBE | LINKEDIN | EVENTS | WEBINARS

YOU KEEP THE BRAND IN FOCUS.
YOU TURN BELIEF INTO ACTION. YOU CREATE LASTING IMPACT.

WHAT THIS COULD LOOK LIKE



MARIA — EXPERT

Weekly video series on YouTube

THE ORANGE COMPANY



ANTHONY — STORYTELLER

Frontline stories on LinkedIn



SUSAN — ADVOCATE

Weekly podcast

ONE COMPANY. THREE TRUSTED VOICES. MULTIPLE WAYS TO BUILD TRUST.

NINE VOICES



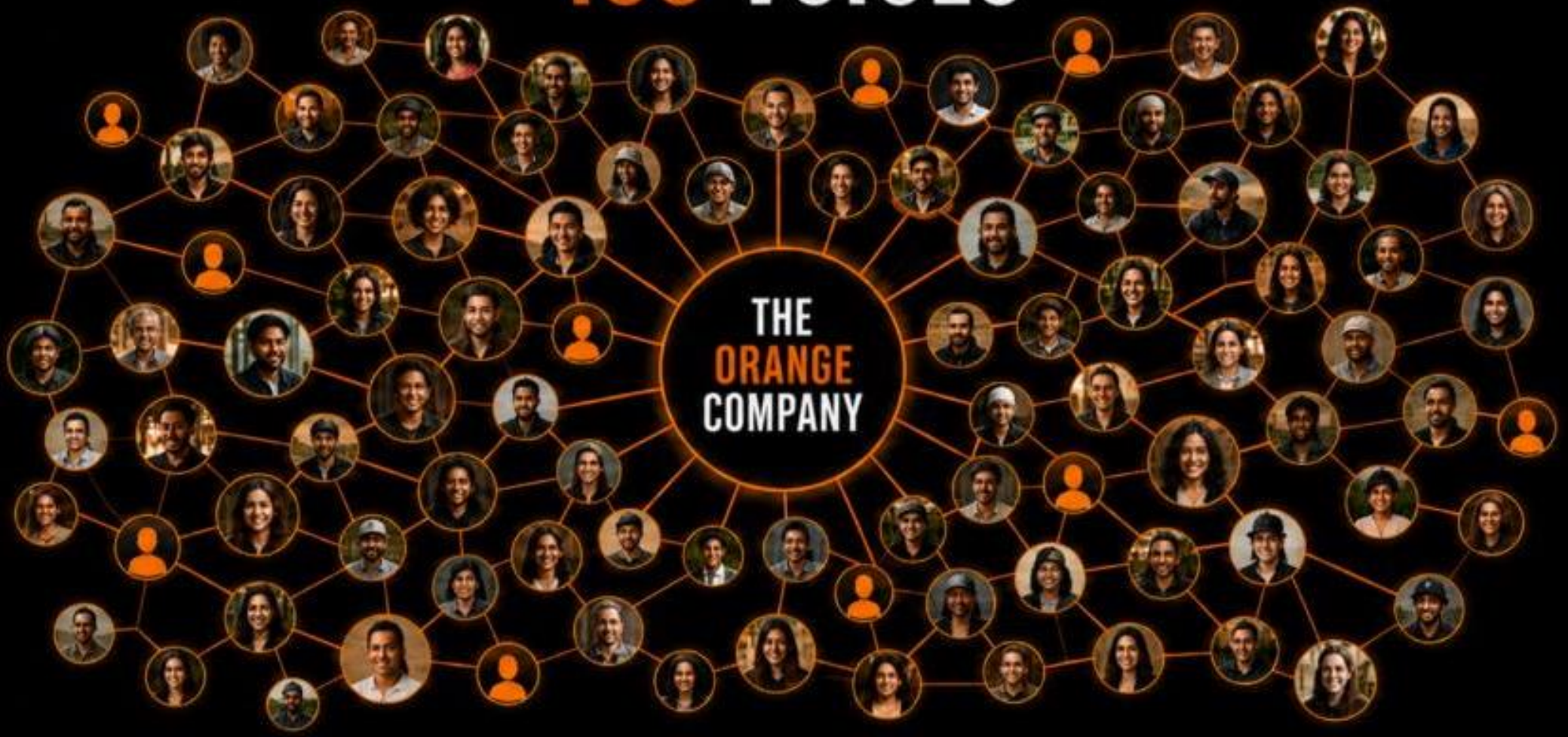
ONE COMPANY. NINE TRUSTED VOICES. EXPANDING REACH.

21 VOICES



ONE COMPANY. TWENTY-ONE TRUSTED VOICES. MULTIPLYING IMPACT.

100 VOICES

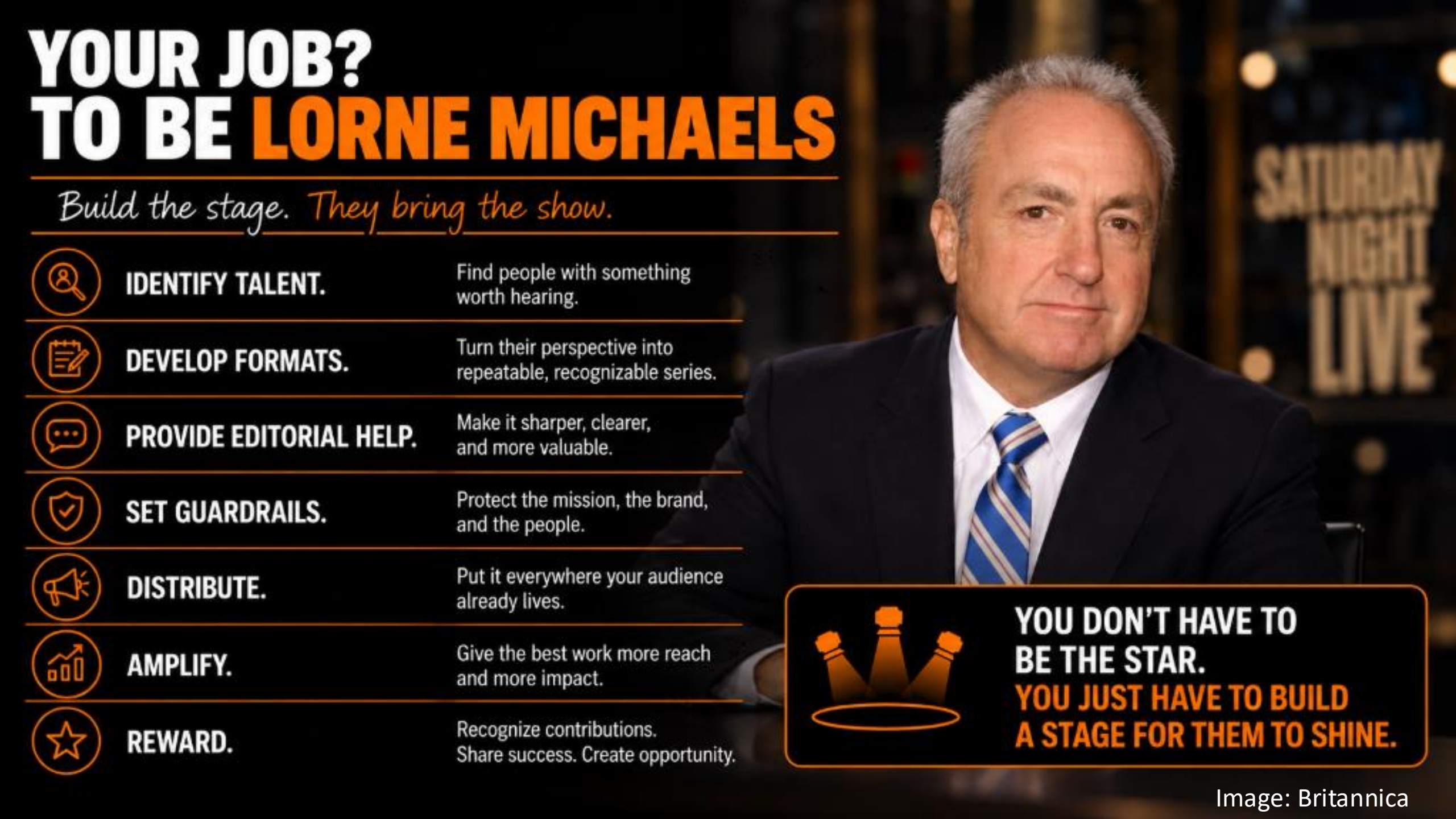


ONE COMPANY. 100 TRUSTED VOICES. AN ENGINE FOR TRUST.

YOUR JOB?
TO BE LORNE MICHAELS

Build the stage. They bring the show.

IDENTIFY TALENT.	Find people with something worth hearing.
DEVELOP FORMATS.	Turn their perspective into repeatable, recognizable series.
PROVIDE EDITORIAL HELP.	Make it sharper, clearer, and more valuable.
SET GUARDRAILS.	Protect the mission, the brand, and the people.
DISTRIBUTE.	Put it everywhere your audience already lives.
AMPLIFY.	Give the best work more reach and more impact.
REWARD.	Recognize contributions. Share success. Create opportunity.



YOU DON'T HAVE TO BE THE STAR.
YOU JUST HAVE TO BUILD A STAGE FOR THEM TO SHINE.

Image: Britannica

WHAT IS THE GOAL OF SNL?



THE TRUST PORTFOLIO

BRING THEM BACK



MORE
SUBSCRIBERS



MORE
LEADS



MORE
PIPELINE



MORE
CUSTOMERS



CUSTOMERS
STAY LONGER



MORE
REFERRALS



HIGHER
CUSTOMER VALUE



MORE
REVENUE

THE ELEPHANT IN THE ROOM



WHAT IF
THE PERSON
LEAVES?



WHAT IF
THEY SAY SOMETHING
WE DON'T LIKE?



WHAT IF
THEY BECOME BIGGER
THAN THE BRAND?

THAT'S WHY IT'S A PORTFOLIO



VS.



ONE OR TWO STOCKS

HIGH RISK. HIGH DEPENDENCE.

DOZENS OF STOCKS

MORE STABLE. STRONGER OVER TIME.

THE TRUST PORTFOLIO

IT'S YOUR STRATEGY



CLEAR GUARDRAILS (legal)



CLEAR OWNERSHIP (yours)



CLEAR EXPECTATIONS (what's the goal?)



CLEAR EXIT PLAN (what happens if they leave)

THE TRUST PORTFOLIO

SNL CONSISTENTLY LOSES STARS



- SNL has lost almost every star it ever created. The portfolio survived.
- Chevy Chase left. Eddie Murphy left. Will Ferrell left. Tina Fey left. Kate McKinnon left.



BEFORE YOU BUILD THE CAST...

FIND THE TRUST GAPS

1. WHERE ARE WE LOSING TRUST?
2. WHICH AUDIENCES MATTER MOST?
3. WHAT QUESTIONS OR DOUBTS ARE HOLDING THEM BACK?

START WITH THE GAPS. THEN BUILD THE CAST.

THE TRUST PORTFOLIO

ASSIGNMENT: WHO'S IN YOUR CAST?

- WHO KNOWS SOMETHING?
- WHO HAS LIVED SOMETHING?
- WHO BELIEVES SOMETHING?



TAKE THE TRUST PORTFOLIO WITH YOU

ARTICLE + WORKSHEET + FIELD GUIDE

SCAN TO GET
EVERYTHING

RESOURCES TO HELP YOU BUILD YOUR FIRST TRUST PORTFOLIO.

NOW IS THE TIME

CONTENT IS GOING INFINITE WITH AI
DON'T CREATE MORE CONTENT.
DESIGN HUMAN-LED CONTENT FRANCHISES.



BUILD THE CAST
BUILD THE FRANCHISES
BUILD THE TRUST

THANK YOU!

SCAN FOR
ARTICLE + WORKSHEET
+ FIELD GUIDE

MAICON FORWARD

JOE PULIZZI

Founder

The Tilt

THANK YOU! WE APPRECIATE YOUR SESSION FEEDBACK.